

HE HEALS THE BROKENHEARTED

A Faith-Integrated PTSD Recovery Workbook

Psalm 147:3 - He heals the broken in heart
and binds up their wounds.

By Daniel Tesfamariam

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IMPORTANT: This workbook does NOT replace trauma therapy.

Please work with a licensed therapist trained in trauma.

Crisis: 988 Lifeline | PTSD Helpline: 1-800-662-4357

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UNDERSTANDING PTSD THROUGH FAITH

Psalm 34:18 - The LORD is close to the brokenhearted

PTSD (Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder) happens when your brain gets stuck in 'danger mode' after a traumatic event.

Symptoms include:

- Flashbacks and nightmares
- Hypervigilance (always on alert)
- Avoidance of reminders
- Emotional numbness
- Difficulty sleeping
- Feeling disconnected from others (including God)

PTSD is NOT:

- A sign of weakness
- Punishment from God
- Something you should 'just get over'
- A lack of faith

PTSD IS a normal response to abnormal events.

Even warriors in the Bible showed trauma responses.

God is NOT distant. He is close (Psalm 34:18).

MY SAFETY PLAN

With Spiritual Supports

Warning signs I'm being triggered:

Things I can do to self-soothe:

People I can call:

Places I feel safe:

Scripture that grounds me:

Prayer I can pray:

My therapist (name/number):

Crisis number: 988

Church support (pastor/group):

Reason to keep going:

GROUNDING IN GOD'S PRESENCE

When triggered or dissociating, use 5-4-3-2-1 + GOD IS HERE:

5 things I can SEE (God created each one - thank Him)

4 things I can TOUCH (press feet to floor - God is my foundation)

3 things I can HEAR (God speaks peace into chaos)

2 things I can SMELL (breathe deep - God's breath gives life)

1 thing I can TASTE (taste and see that the LORD is good)

PRESENCE MEDITATION:

'God is here. I am safe. This moment is not that moment.'

'The LORD is my shepherd. I am not in danger right now.'

'I am in [location]. It is [year]. I am safe.'

'God holds me. I can feel my body. I am present.'

TRIGGER IDENTIFICATION + SCRIPTURE ANCHORS

Identify triggers and pair each with a scripture anchor:

Trigger 1: _____

Scripture anchor: _____

What I'll do when triggered: _____

Trigger 2: _____

Scripture anchor: _____

What I'll do when triggered: _____

Trigger 3: _____

Scripture anchor: _____

What I'll do when triggered: _____

Trigger 4: _____

Scripture anchor: _____

What I'll do when triggered: _____

Trigger 5: _____

Scripture anchor: _____

What I'll do when triggered: _____

Trigger 6: _____

Scripture anchor: _____

What I'll do when triggered: _____

WINDOW OF TOLERANCE

Psalm 46:10 - Be still and know that I am God

HYPERAROUSAL (too activated):

Racing heart, panic, rage, can't sit still

-> Calm down: Breathe, ground, 'Be still...'

WINDOW OF TOLERANCE

(Safe zone - where healing happens)

HYPOAROUSAL (too shut down):

Numb, frozen, disconnected, can't feel

-> Activate: Move body, cold water, 'Awake, O my soul!'

Right now I am:

☐ Hyperaroused

☐ In my window

☐ Hypoaroused

STUCK POINTS ABOUT GOD

After trauma, many struggle with questions about God:

'Why did God allow this?'

God did not cause this. We live in a broken world. He weeps with you (John 11:35).

'God didn't protect me'

Evil people have free will. God promises to redeem, not to prevent all pain (Rom 8:28).

'I must have deserved it'

NO. God does not punish through trauma. You did not deserve this (John 9:2-3).

'God can't be good if this happened'

God's goodness includes being WITH you in suffering (Psalm 23:4 - through the valley).

After writing, pray: 'Lord, I give this to You. Heal me. Amen.'

SELF-COMPASSION AS GOD SEES YOU

Psalm 139 - You are fearfully and wonderfully made

God says: 'I knew you before you were born' (Jeremiah 1:5)

God says: 'You are precious in my eyes' (Isaiah 43:4)

God says: 'I will never leave you' (Hebrews 13:5)

God says: 'Nothing can separate you from my love' (Romans 8:38-39)

God says: 'I make all things new' (Revelation 21:5)

Write a letter of compassion to yourself:

RECLAIMING YOUR BODY AS GOD'S TEMPLE

1 Corinthians 6:19

Trauma often disconnects us from our bodies.

Your body is not the enemy - it is God's temple.

Gentle ways to reconnect:

- Stretching while praying (yoga-style + scripture)
- Walking in nature (God's creation)
- Deep breathing (receiving God's breath of life)
- Warm bath/shower (water as cleansing/baptism)
- Noticing your body without judgment

Affirmation: 'My body carried me through the worst day.

It deserves kindness, not punishment. God dwells here.'

What's one way I can be kind to my body today?

WEEKLY TRACKER - WEEK 1

Day	Distress	Sleep	Flashbacks?	Grounded?	Prayer?	Safe?
Mon						
Tue						
Wed						
Thu						
Fri						
Sat						
Sun						

Where I saw God this week:

One thing I'm grateful for:

WEEKLY TRACKER - WEEK 2

Day	Distress	Sleep	Flashbacks?	Grounded?	Prayer?	Safe?
Mon						
Tue						
Wed						
Thu						
Fri						
Sat						
Sun						

Where I saw God this week:

One thing I'm grateful for:

WEEKLY TRACKER - WEEK 3

Day	Distress	Sleep	Flashbacks?	Grounded?	Prayer?	Safe?
Mon						
Tue						
Wed						
Thu						
Fri						
Sat						
Sun						

Where I saw God this week:

One thing I'm grateful for:

WEEKLY TRACKER - WEEK 4

Day	Distress	Sleep	Flashbacks?	Grounded?	Prayer?	Safe?
Mon						
Tue						
Wed						
Thu						
Fri						
Sat						
Sun						

Where I saw God this week:

One thing I'm grateful for:

WEEKLY TRACKER - WEEK 5

Day	Distress	Sleep	Flashbacks?	Grounded?	Prayer?	Safe?
Mon						
Tue						
Wed						
Thu						
Fri						
Sat						
Sun						

Where I saw God this week:

One thing I'm grateful for:

POST-TRAUMATIC GROWTH THROUGH FAITH

Many trauma survivors report unexpected growth:

- Deeper faith and relationship with God
- Greater compassion for others who suffer
- Clearer sense of what truly matters
- Stronger relationships (authentic vulnerability)
- New purpose (helping others heal)

Romans 8:28 doesn't mean trauma was 'good.'

It means God can bring good FROM it.

Growth I've noticed in myself:

RESOURCES

- 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline: Call or text 988
- SAMHSA Helpline: 1-800-662-4357
- PTSD Foundation of America
- Celebrate Recovery (church-based)
- EMDR therapists (emdr.com)
- Faith-based trauma counselors
- Trauma-informed church resources
- Books: 'The Body Keeps the Score' by Bessel van der Kolk

You are not broken beyond repair.

He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds.

- Psalm 147:3